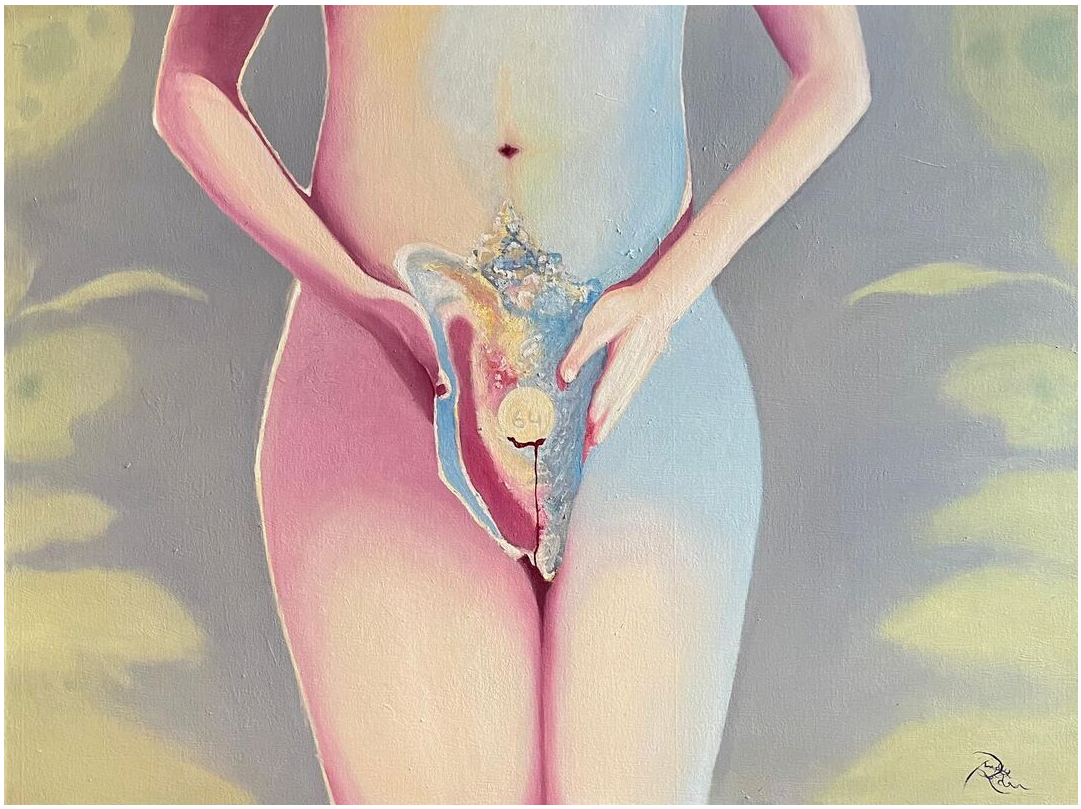
Madelyn Roldan: Ekphrastic Writing Responses, Curated by Kate Copeland

10/2/2026 0 Comments



Easy Way Out, by Madelyn Roldan (USA) 2025

Death of Snow White

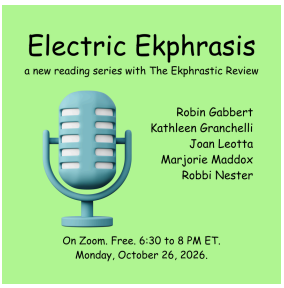
Our future queen,
While still a teenage princess,
Rebelled against
Her fate of giving birth
To hordes of bees--
The countless honey workers
In golden mines,
The grumpy dopey clones.

CURRENT PROMPT

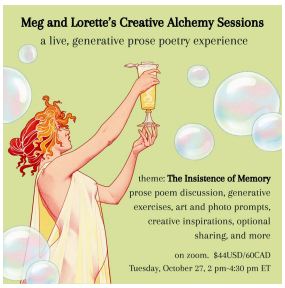
Search

Challenges

Here is where you will find the twice monthly challenges and selected responses.







tests results from the tissue, actually his name was Jack
Trisomy 13 it said, not compatible with life it said
absolutely nothing you had done, they said
the months that followed were bleak
I lost hope, gave up trying
and then almost a year later, it happened for real
a most stunning baby boy that wiped clean all that had come before
a rainbow baby they said
a few years later, Poppy, miscarriage number eight
then time was up, we would try no more
almost twelve years on and those peachy pink and blue pastels
make me wonder what happened to the Sylvia cup
donated to charity, in storage, or smashed to cathartic smithereens?
any could be true.

Susan Philip

Susan lives in Scotland with her son, husband, dog and five cats. She recently embarked on an MA Creative Writing and Wellbeing, and is interested in all aspects of writing for healing. She writes memoir, fiction, poetry, and creative non-fiction.

**

It was my day off, and I was in my living room, thumbing through the pages of Mrs McGinty's Dead, a book I had enjoyed in my teenage years, when the first jolt of pain rippled in my belly. Frowning, I trudged to the kitchen. The top left shelf housed painkillers, antibiotics, and first-aid kits. I popped a paracetamol tablet in my mouth, and one again for good measure, swishing them noisily with a swig of orange juice. As they slid down my throat, the old pain, heightened tenfold this time, fell against my abdomen like the swash of a mighty wave.

"It can't be period cramps," I spluttered. I had been on birth control for the last two months, in a desperate attempt to ward off acne breakouts. Perhaps it was food-poisoning, though I couldn't recall eating anything particularly greasy.

I plopped down on the living room floor, massaging my belly. The pain did not subside; it scraped the bottom half of my body, insistently making pinprick sounds, like a very small creature begging to be let out. My body grew cold as I entertained the possibility that something was growing in my stomach.

"I haven't done anything," I whispered. It was true – I hadn't so much as touched a man. I was as devout a Muslim as they come, and likely asexual. But I found myself unassured nonetheless.

What if someone had slipped inside my bedroom in the dead of the night?

"You're insane," I told myself, my warbling voice failing to imitate firmness. The bedroom window had been glued shut since the beginning of time, and I always bolted the door before I went to bed. No, I had probably forgotten a few doses. That was the only explanation. Yet, despite presenting myself with these logical counterbalances, my heart thrummed noisily, and beads of sweat rolled down my neck.

The apartment door creaked open and my roommate Jenna surfaced from the gap. "Christ," she said. "Are you okay?" A warm fluid spread across my thighs.

"I think so," I said shakily.

I wearily attempted a fistbump before locking myself in my bathroom. I undressed and watched ribbons of blood drip down my legs. I sighed, disappointed the birth control had failed, but relieved that it was just my period, nothing more.

Pain lurching in my belly still, I cleaned up and headed to the kitchen for more paracetamol.

"Oh God," said Jenna. "You look awful."

"Rude," I said irritably. "I got my period. Turns out my birth control doesn't work."

"Uh-uh," she said. Warm blood pooled in my pelvic region, forming an ominous-looking splotch on my trousers.

The pain metastasized, pressing like a mantle against my arms, my legs, and my head.

I began to waver in and out of consciousness. The cosmos spun around me like a tendril. As I took in its numinous beauty, the damned pain speared me, as if the growth (if there was one) wanted to punish me for doubting its existence. The pain made the cosmos recede, transporting me to a foggy, decaying city, where several women with distended stomachs, myself included, repeatedly chanted "My body, my choice!" Severe-looking men shook their fists at us, and my parents looked on in disappointment.

The pain took me back to a preposterous childhood myth, in which geckos would dart inside the closets of little girls and lay undetectable eggs on their clothes. Any girl who wore the tainted clothes would be afflicted with a tumid belly, and an unsightly half-gecko, half-human child.

My organs writhed uncontrollably, and I reflexively pushed, pushed, pushed.

A gristly, metallic-smelling lump slid from my legs onto the floor. It was sodden with blood and mucus. The growth. The pain had abated, but I couldn't stop shuddering.

Jenna hauled me into her car, reclining my seat so that I could rest. Bathed in sweat, I grew immobile with guilt and anger. I had let something grow inside me, not knowing I had, definitely not wanting to. What would my parents think? What would everyone think? My thoughts would go back to the girls with the gecko babies. The half-forgotten memories were inexplicably clear. In every tale, the little girls would be banished from their homes, forced to raise their spawn alone, or murder them out of desperation.

In my state, the Planned Parenthood facility appeared filtered in pink. It was inside a strip mall, and spiral cypress topiaries framed its entrance. Jenna jogged along, eyes lit with concern, as a nurse wheeled me inside a small room with blinding overhead lights. Trembling, I recounted the events to a kindly-looking, thirty-something doctor. She took my vitals and made me pee in a cup.

"Everything's normal. Your friend brought the lump along. Sounds disgusting, I know, but she did the right thing," she said.

"What is it?" I stammered.

"Nothing serious, thankfully. A decidual cast."

"What's that?"

"It means your uterine lining came out in one piece. Think of it as a mega period. We'll get you an ultrasound, just to be safe."

In another room, another doctor laid me down on a narrow bed and smeared translucent gel on my belly, pressing it with a pump-like instrument. By the edge of the bed was a black screen. I stared at it blankly, unable to stop fretting over the decidual cast. I couldn't believe I had been so ignorant as to be completely unaware of the phenomenon, fifteen years into adolescence.

"Nothing to see here," the doctor said pleasantly. "You're good to go." Jenna squeezed my hand.

On the car ride back home, a heavy feeling settled over me. Whether it was a delayed sense of relief, or shame, or gratitude for the kindness of Jenna and the Planned Parenthood staff, or because I mourned the fate of the little girls, I didn't know.

Fatima Sajjad

Fatima Sajjad is a writer from Karachi, Pakistan. She finished her MFA in creative writing at the University of South Florida in 2026, where she was also a fiction editor for *Saw Palm Magazine.*

**

64

She drove toward town and her appointment, her rusty truck complaining. There was no bus service out here on the edge of the woods. Her woods, for a few weeks more. Eminent domain had taken care of that, thanks to the Kelo v City of New London decision. Come winter, the trees would be felled, and the road would be widened, and where her little house now stood (a blight, the councilmen had said), construction would begin on the new housing development. She guessed bus service would soon follow. But she'd be gone.

She pulled the truck over to the shoulder, lowered her window, and inhaled autumn. She'd imagined raising kids out here, taking them on mushroom hunts. Grandkids too, she could hear them stomping leaves and laughing. A crow swooped low and blapped her windshield. She snorted. Yep, poop on those plans.

Still, the math gnawed at her. If she had two kids, and each of them brought two babies into the world and so on, within four generations she would have 64 descendants. Well, maybe the math wasn't that neat, but roughly 64. And they'd have 64 vehicles, and 64 apartments, or condos, or worse, McMansions. She started the truck, eased it back onto the pavement as a squirrel ran halfway across the road, then doubled back. Pick a lane, buddy. There's room for both of us.

But was there? As the truck sputtered its way toward town, toward the clinic, she held her belly and wondered.

Tracy Royce

Tracy Royce is a writer and poet with work appearing in *100 Word Story, Bending Genres, Flash Frontier,* and *Best Microfiction* (2026). Tracy's poems have been nominated for a Pushcart Prize and Best Small Fictions. She lives in Southern California, where she enjoys hiking by day and film noir